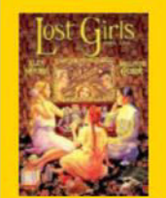


MUST-READ MOORE The best of Moore's comics



V FOR VENDETTA

A stark vision of a totalitarian Britain – gorgeously rendered by David Lloyd – Moore's passionate protest against Thatcherite ideals of greed, jingoism and anti-unionism remains one of his finest works, still potent 25 years on. The story of an anarchist terrorist's battles against a fascist UK government is also the first glimpse of Moore's massive potential.



LOST GIRLS

Sixteen years in the making, this is Moore's unabashed paean to pornography – and utterly beautiful it is too. Despite the controversy-baiting premise – *Wonderland*'s Alice, *Oz*'s Dorothy and *Peter Pan*'s Wendy meet in Austria and engage in a vast sexual imbroglio – Moore treats his subject with affection, sincerity and sensitivity. One of his most personal works.



SWAMP THING

The series that introduced Moore to the US market. He was on pioneering form, deconstructing and re-imagining a then-formulaic character, infusing the series with an intense strain of urban horror that at the time was truly startling. DC Comics' entire mature-readers oeuvre can be traced back to Moore's work here.



FROM HELL

The chief rival to *Watchmen* for the title of Moore's very best work, this fictionalised assessment of the Jack The Ripper murders is a breathtaking accomplishment – dense, multilayered and immensely detailed. Deeply compelling and oddly beautiful, Moore confronts his subject head on, especially in the unflinchingly graphic rendition of Mary Kelly's death.



THE LEAGUE OF EXTRAORDINARY GENTLEMAN

Even the overwhelmingly poor quality of the 2003 film version cannot reduce the sheer greatness of the source comic, drawn by Kevin O'Neill, that was the crown jewel in Moore's 'America's Best Comics' imprint. Its marvellously simple and captivating premise – the Victorian adventure fiction characters operating in a 'super-group' – ensured that it was a massive hit.

anything necessarily. So I did tend to evolve this thing where I did a complete script where I would talk about everything from camera angles to lighting to ambience to emotional atmosphere to the inner motivations of the character, what they are thinking, what expressions they have got on their faces – very, very thorough. I think that most artists tend to enjoy that.

Frank Miller once commented that, with *Watchmen*, you performed the autopsy on superheroes, while he got to perform the brass-band funeral with *The Dark Knight Returns*. Do you agree with that?

In a lot of instances you'll find *Watchmen* and *Dark Knight* grouped together, and this is because both came out of the same comic company at the same time. They both showed a darker vision of the superhero. I think that there is an essential big difference between them, though. At the time, when I was doing *Watchmen*, somewhere in my head I got this vainglorious notion that *Watchmen* would be the absolute deconstructionist last word on the superhero, and that somehow, mystically, after it had been published, all the superhero book publishers would, I don't know, turn to westerns or something like that, but it would be impossible to do superhero comics afterward – which was completely stupid and a completely misplaced hope. What you really got afterwards was a kind of more pretentious superhero comics, often with a lot more nasty, gratuitous violence. *Dark Knight* was certainly a grimmer picture of Batman, but if you look at the subtext of both books – in *Watchmen*, all of the characters are flawed in some way. There is no way that they work in terms of the conventional idea of the hero. Their presence is more of a problem for the world that they inhabit than any kind of ray of salvation or hope. With *Watchmen*, I was actually exploring the real-world ramifications of these characters and ideas. There was that big difference between what *Dark Knight* and *Watchmen*. They're two very different works.

Alongside the widespread acclaim that *Watchmen* and *The Dark Knight Returns* received, they are often accused of kick-starting the 'grim 'n' gritty' period that followed in the superhero genre, which was often done rather ham-fistedly. Do you think that was a regrettable element of the book's success?

I think it was me who first actually blamed *Watchmen* and *Dark Knight* for kick-starting that. At the time, I found it rather depressing. I felt that *Watchmen* in particular had a deleterious effect on the industry; there was all of this joyless grimness everywhere. *Watchmen* was actually not about grim superheroes. The only thing I was interested in *Watchmen* for, and the only thing I remain interested for, is the storytelling. The elaborate, crystalline story structure... the insanely detailed dove-tailing of imagery and words and I hoped that if people took anything from *Watchmen* it would be that. But, unfortunately, I guess it was easier to take Rorshach's brutality or the cynical, world-weary viewpoint.

What are your feelings on the state of the superhero genre?

I think that there are some individual good works. Generally, I think it's completely dead in the water and exhausted. You'll get people like Warren Ellis who has a freshness to his imagination. On the other hand, you have someone like Mike Allred, doing his weird, nostalgic, demented vision of superheroes. For a while, I was getting 'The Big DC'... I think it was Garth Ennis who referred to it as 'The Big DC Bag of Shite'... but that's what we all call it now. I've got them to stop sending it to me recently as it was just so depressing. I don't even read Marvel Comics, but I'm assured that the situation is as bad there, if not worse.

Much has been made of *Watchmen*'s apparent cinematic nature – do you agree with this?

Most people looking at *Watchmen* who were unfamiliar with comics would evaluate it with something that they are familiar with – whether that be film, so you get people saying "*Watchmen* is very cinematic", when actually it's not. It's almost the exact opposite to cinematic. When I met with Terry Gilliam – who was at one point proposed to be the director of a *Watchmen* film – and he asked me how I would film it, I had to tell him that if anyone had asked me earlier, I would have told them that, frankly, I didn't think it was filmable. Because, I kind of designed it not to show off the similarities between cinema and comics, which *are* there, but, in my opinion are fairly unremarkable. It was to show off the things